



Sound Healing Workshop



The Magic of Tibetan Singing Bowls

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The History of Tibetan Singing Bowls

Singing bowls have been used for healing and spiritual purposes in the Himalayan region for thousands of years. The history of these bowls is somewhat cloaked in mystery. They likely date back to the time of Buddha (around 400 BCE). Buddhists in Nepal, Bhutan and China used the bowls for prayer and rituals. It is believed they were used by monks in Himalayan monasteries for secret and sacred practices that were never written down or shared with outsiders. Legends also say that the bowls were used by Nepalese women during their pregnancies to eat from the bowls in order to get minerals intake. When a Tibetan King in the 11th century married a Nepalese woman, she supposedly carried the bowls with her to Tibet where they became more popular.

When foreigners came to Tibet in the last century, they were intrigued by the look and sound of these bowls. The term Tibetan Singing Bowls was likely to be coined by salesmen during the 1960s. Many Westerners seemed to be drawn to crafts and artefacts from the mythical Tibet with its rich culture and spirituality. They made their way from the Himalayan mountains to homes, yoga studios, healing centres and sound healing spaces all over the world. We might never find out the real history and use of these bowls, yet they have become a widely recognized tool for sound healing.

How the Singing Bowls are made

The main production sites of singing bowls are currently in Nepal and North India. There are handmade bowls as well as mass-produced bowls available.

The singing bowls come in a variety of sizes, compositions and ornamentation. Traditionally, they were all handmade from an alloy of metals. The process is hard work, from melting the metals to reheating and hand hammering the bowls into shape. Each metal was carefully selected for its resonant qualities and its representation of cosmic energies, with raw materials often chosen in relation to specific planets and chakras.

The main material is an alloy of copper (about 80%) and tin (about 20%) – also called bronze, a bell metal alloy -, sometimes combined with zinc and iron, silver and gold in very small quantities. As mercury and lead have been found to be poisonous, they are no longer used. The decoration of the bowls may display mandalas, yantras or sacred prayers in Sanskrit or Pali scripture.

The sound of Tibetan Singing Bowls

The Tibetan singing bowls are rich in frequencies and produce magical effects, as various notes sound at the same time. When examining the notes of the singing bowls, we find 3 to 4 main notes that sound together plus a variety of harmonics (overtones). When singing bowls are played together, it creates a rich tapestry of sounds, with different frequencies and harmonics overlapping each other. Additional frequencies might become audible when two or more bowls are played simultaneously. No two handmade bowls will sound the same!

The main notes of the bowls usually do not fit into our Western musical concept of 12 diatonic notes (like the black & white keys on a piano). The Tibetan Singing Bowls have their own harmonic beauty. The more we can allow ourselves to listen without preconceived musical concepts or ideas, the easier we can appreciate the uniqueness of the singing bowl sounds.

The collection of Singing Bowls at Udara

At Udara, we have collected a beautiful array of singing bowls from Nepal in various sizes and forms. From the smallest bowls that just fit into the palm of your hand to the huge bowls that you can even stand inside and feel the vibration travel up your whole body. We use the Singing Bowls as part of each Sound Healing ceremony. They are part of the Udara Sundays, where we offer Sound Healing after Ecstatic Dance, we have special evenings where we play the singing bowls in the Sauna and in the warm water floating pool, or as part of Yin yoga classes and Cacao ceremonies. In our new Quantum sound healing domes, you can experience the exquisite resonance of the bowls during various daily ceremonies.

Techniques and equipment to play the bowls

To strike the bowls, we can use various mallets, such as wooden mallets covered with velour on one end or felted mallets with a longer handle. The difference in mallets and the way how the bowls are brought into vibration create specific sound effects. We can do single strikes at the upper part of the bowl as well as circling the mallet around the outside of the bowl to create a continuous sound. Smaller mallets are used for smaller bowls, bigger mallets for bigger bowls.

The bowls need to be placed on a stable yet padded surface to create the best sound. Don't place them directly on wooden or tiled floors and also not on zippers or buttons when you place them on someone's body. Some bowls already come with a ring shaped pillow that you can use as a stand for the floor.

Hold the bowl in your flat hand, so the sound can resonate freely. When you want to strike the bowl, you can do so at a light angle and let the mallet in your hand swing like a pendulum towards the bowl for the hit. Usually we hit the bowl from the outside on the upper part of the bowl (at the rim or 1-3 centimetres below). Experiment with different intensities and ways to hit e.g. striking directly towards the bowl or creating an upward movement as you strike.

For the circling (or rimming), press the mallet towards the bowl from the outside and circle around the upper part of the bowl slowly and with pressure. You might need a light hit first in order to start the vibrations for the continuous sound. You can circle around both ways. Some traditions suggest that circling in a clockwise direction represents masculine energy, while circling counter-clockwise represents feminine energy. Experiment with holding the bowl close to your open mouth and make different shapes with your mouth cavity to change the resonance.

The more you play and get comfortable with the singing bowls, the less you will have to think about your technique. You will find your way to create beautiful sound with the volume that you intended.

Different ways to use Singing Bowls

Singing bowls can be used on various occasions and for different purposes. We can continue the sacred tradition of the bowls for rituals, prayers and ceremonies. They can also accompany a relaxation journey or meditation session. The most common use is for sound healing journeys in groups or private sessions. Tibetan Singing Bowls can be combined with other instruments and also become a tool to accompany chanting (e.g. mantras singing or toning of vowels).

Singing Bowls can enhance sessions of other modalities such as Reiki, Bodywork or Aquatic Therapies (the bowls float in water and create beautiful sounds you can hear with your ears under water).

What is Sound Healing?

Sound Healing is the specific use of frequencies to promote healing and balance. Sound can have profound effects on our health and wellbeing, whether we actively listen to music, play an instrument, move to the beat of the music or receive beneficial frequencies in a passive way. It addresses various planes of our existence, from the physical to the emotional and spiritual level by using different instruments and the voice. In essence, it helps us align more deeply with ourselves and synchronize with the natural laws, structure, and order of the cosmos. In general, Sound Healing therapy is based on the principle that all of life is vibration, including our own bodies. When our resonant frequency is out of balance, physical and emotional health is affected.

New Science based on Ancient Beliefs

For several decades, scientists have shown increasing interest in understanding how Sound Healing works and how it can be used to treat various illnesses, in conjunction with allopathic medicine or even as a stand-alone treatment. Edgar Cayce predicted that “Sound is the medicine of the future.” Science is rapidly evolving and it will be fascinating to witness new findings about the healing power of sound.

Ancient people already knew that everything is vibration and even Albert Einstein supposedly said “Everything is energy and that’s all there is to it. Match the frequency of the reality you want and you cannot help but get that reality. It can be no other way. This is not philosophy. This is physics.” Since the rise of Quantum Physics, which aims to explain the model of reality and the existence from the micro to the macrocosm, we experience a huge paradigm shift. The previous split of spirituality and science, the disconnection of body and mind seems to slowly disintegrate, to be replaced with not only the belief, but with scientific evidence that everything and everyone is interconnected in a sea of vibration.

How the Sound of Tibetan Singing Bowls work

Sound is a continuous and regular vibration that travels through air and other mediums. The **frequency** of a sound is the speed of the vibration per second, measured in Hertz. For humans, audible sounds are between 20 and 20.000 Hz. When sound reaches our ears, it travels up the auditory nerve into our brain where it is processed. Sounds can then trigger **bodily responses** by changing brain chemicals, for example altering our heart rate, blood pressure, emotional state or muscle tension.

Sound not only travels through air, it even travels faster through water and much faster through bone. Knowing that our bodies are made up of about 70% water, we realize the **potency of sound** vibrations that go straight to all cells of our body.

Sound affects us on so many different levels, from the cellular function to the tissues, hormones, brain waves and the flow of energy in our body. Sound does not only work within the body, but also on the aura, the bioelectrical field around the body, which can be harmonized with sound.

When Singing Bowls are played, we do not only hear the notes but actually feel the vibrations in our bodies. Our whole body is a sensory organ for sound. The cells in the body are nourished and reorganized by these beneficial sounds that help us to come back “**in tune**” according to our unique blueprint, our natural vibration that is deeply interconnected with the harmony and beauty of nature and the cosmos.

The sound of the bowls help to slow down and harmonize the brain waves. It creates more coherent brain waves and helps to enter into Theta or Delta states that are conducive for meditative awareness, calming of the nervous system, healing and deep rest for body and mind. Sound can act as a medium for our bodies to heal themselves through **entrainment**. When the sound healer introduces beneficial frequencies during the sound therapy, the body gets a signal to move towards this frequency and match the ‘healthy’ sound vibration. Natural, primordial sounds are much more effective in this regard, as they represent the inherent harmonious order of nature in contrast to electronic music, which creates only a shorter and less profound effect of entertainment.

The intention that we put into the sound healing sessions (both as a giver and as a receiver) are as important as the frequencies themselves. Jonathan Goldman, a pioneer of the recent rise in Sound Healing created the formula “**Frequency + Intention = Healing**”. Thoughts can be seen as a form of energy and as we add beneficial, health-promoting, heart-centred intentions into the process, the results of the sound healing are magnified.

Benefits of the Tibetan Singing Bowl Sound Healing

The effects of sound healing with Tibetan Singing Bowls (and other instruments) may include:

- stress reduction
- emotional balance
- lowered blood pressure
- soothing the nervous system
- improved sleep
- muscle relaxation
- more coherence in the brain waves
- deepening meditative states, calming the mind
- pain relief
- inducing higher states of consciousness

How to choose a singing bowl for yourself

When purchasing a singing bowl from Nepal or India, the price is generally determined by the weight of the bowl. Special bowls are available such as Full Moon bowls, which are produced on full moon nights and are supposedly carrying higher energetic potential for healing. Ancient singing bowls are sold at high prices, yet for a layperson, it can be difficult to discern whether they are truly ancient or merely made to appear so.

Handmade bowls usually produce a richer sound that feels more “alive”. During different stages of your life, different kinds of bowls might speak to you. Your selection of bowls may grow with you, as you get more attuned to the nuances of the sounds and their effects on yourself and others.

You can also purchase a set of singing bowls that are designed to work on the seven main chakras, in which each bowl connects to one of the chakras (see below). Other sets may be based on certain harmonies, such as chords. Yet as the bowls are handmade, it will be difficult to find a set of bowls that exactly match the notes of the Western diatonic scale (like on a piano). Singing Bowls might also be tuned to the frequency of a planet such as Saturn or Venus. But as each bowl contains various frequencies, there is no bowl affecting “just” one chakra or being connected to just a single musical note.

When you want to buy a bowl for your own use, let your intuition guide you which one to pick. Play different kinds of bowls and feel how your body and mind respond to it.

- Do you feel a sense of calm?
- Does the sound move and touch you?
- Do you feel a change in your energy?
- Does it feel easy to tone or sing along with the sound of the bowl?

Playing singing bowls for yourself

Develop a connection with your singing bowls and play them for various purposes, such as letting the sounds guide you into meditation, opening & closing your yoga practice with the sound of the bowls, playing the bowls before you go to sleep, in a working break to refresh your mind, when you ponder over a decision or when you feel emotionally charged. Try singing with the sounds of the bowls, move them around your body as you play or lie down and place a bowl on your body. If you have a big bowl, you can even put it on your head carefully like a hat and strike it for a more intense experience. Note how the bowls affect you and how they are able to enrich your daily life.

Let your playing be an exploration of meditative listening. Move the bowl around, close to the surface of your body while playing it, focus on a certain body part as you strike, place a bowl on your body and feel its vibration, or move the bowl through your energy field (the aura), have the bowl close to your ear as you play to discover all the different notes that are contained in the bowl and how the sound changes with different ways of playing.

Different Chakra Sound Healing Systems

In India and Tibet, we find different systems of notes corresponding to the seven main Chakras. Certain sound healing schools offer chakra sets of singing bowls and teach you a very specific protocol for a sound healing session to balance the chakras, such as how often and how intense you strike a certain bowl and where you place the bowls around the body.

No	Chakra	Vedic Note (Indian tradition)	Tibetan Note
7	Crown	B	B
6	Third eye	A	E
5	Throat	G	A
4	Heart	F	D
3	Solar plexus	E	G
2	Sacral	D	C
1	Root	C	F

Some sound healers work purely intuitively and feel which bowl wants to go to a certain chakra or body part. When you start your sound healing journey, experiment with both of these systems and get a feeling for the different effects. Practice for yourself and others and allow your intuition to develop, from merely hearing the sounds to feeling the vibrations and their effects on subtler levels of energy.

Playing Singing Bowls for someone else

Singing Bowls can be used as a stand-alone instrument or combined with other sound healing instruments such as flutes, rain makers, gongs or rattles.

Tingshas (small Tibetan cymbals) are traditionally used as a signal to start and end a session and to clear the energy of the room and people in it.

When you play the bowls, you are part of the sound healing process. Your own mental-emotional state and level of awareness will influence the sound healing. The most powerful healing can occur when you become highly intuitive and fully present. Remember to play with intention, e.g. for the highest outcome, sending love and compassion, praying for healing, health and harmony.

Here are some initial ideas and guidelines for getting started as a sound healing practitioner, including some Do's & Don'ts

Preparation:

- Ask about the intention or certain areas the receiver likes to focus on
- Build connection, have a short conversation before the session
- Center yourself and ground, take a few conscious, deep breaths before playing
- Cleanse the space and the practitioner (sage, palo santo, tingsha)
- Allow the receiver to settle in and guide him into relaxation
- Set your intentions, silently speaking affirmations or a prayer to amplify the outcome before you start playing

Client:

- Remember not to put bowls on buttons, big necklaces or zippers
- Loose comfortable clothes for the receiver
- Padding under the head or knees, blanked if needed

Placement of the bowls and how to play them:

- Place the singing bowl on the body if the receiver is comfortable with it e.g., on the belly or chest, or on the back if you work on a massage table and can have the receiver lying face down for half of the session
- When you want to place a bowl on the body, touch the body part lightly before you place the bowl on it. Stabilize the bowl with one finger in the center of the bowl before you hit it (circling will not work well on the body)
- Place the bowls around the body if you work with a set of bowls according to the different chakra systems (Vedic or Tibetan) or intuitively (generally bigger bowls more grounding around the lower body, smaller bowls lighter around the head area)
- Walk slowly & quietly around the receiver while you play, hit the bowl or circle the sound
- Be mindful about how close you can put the bowl around the ears before it becomes too loud
- Scan the aura, notice changes in energy field, volume or harmonics of the sound or focus on the chakras (especially when the receiver is face-down and you can “scan” the spine with its corresponding chakra locations)

How to play for someone:

- Less is more – give space between notes so the bowls can resonate
- Watch the receiver, body language and facial expression
- Be mindful of walking around quietly, avoid sudden movements
- Vary with the intensity of strikes, yet be mindful not to play too loud and abrupt, as this may take the receiver out of their relaxed state
- It's very meditative to repeatedly hit the bowls
- You could do a whole session with just 1 - 3 bowls!
- While sound healing can be very pleasing to the ear, the aim is not to perform a musical concert with the bowls
- Silence is part of sound healing after playing the instruments, for the experience to integrate and settle
- Give the receiver time to come out after finishing the session and re-ground
- Sometimes the receiver wants to stay quiet in their own space after the session. If you like to have feedback, offer to give it to you later when he feels like talking.

May your sound healing journey unfold in the most beautiful and beneficial way!